



“They are churning out short-term trainees to meet targets. But short-term training of three months under the PMKVY is not sufficient to impart proper skills”

SANTOSH MEHROTRA
LABOUR ECONOMIST AND
RETIRED JNU PROFESSOR



“We need to tie up with industries and skill according to their requirements. We also need to increase the vocationalisation of secondary education, making it a part of the curricula”

JAYANT KRISHNA
NON-RESIDENT SENIOR
FELLOW, CSIS, & FORMER CEO,
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The Economic Survey 2024-25 too had called for a forward-looking strategy that prepares the workforce for emerging opportunities. Mehrotra says the government should consider giving all graduates a chance to become apprentices for one year.

A start has been made on this front with the Pradhan Mantri Internship Scheme. However, low stipends have led to a poor response from candidates. For instance, in the first round of the pilot, of the 127,000 opportunities posted, just over 8,700 candidates joined. In the second round, more than 455,000 applications were received from over 214,000 applicants. Partner companies had made 72,000 offers as on July 23, of which just 22,800 were accepted.

A FRESH PUSH

Cognisant of several of these concerns, the government has been undertaking various initiatives to reinvent its skilling initiatives. Prime Minister Naren-

dra Modi, earlier this month, launched the PM-SETU Scheme for upgrading 1,000 ITIs with a budget of ₹60,000 crore. The scheme will follow a hub-and-spoke model comprising 200 hub ITIs and 800 spokes. Each hub will be connected to four spokes on average, creating clusters equipped with advanced infrastructure, modern trades, digital learning systems and incubation facilities. Anchor industry partners will manage these clusters, ensuring outcome-based skill-ing aligned with market demand. The prime minister also inaugurated 1,200 vocational skill labs in 400 Navodaya Vidyalayas and 200 Eklavya Model Residential Schools across 34 states and Union Territories which are expected to equip students, including those in remote and tribal areas, with hands-on training in 12 high-demand sectors.

PMKVY 4.0 is also providing training for new-age roles such as AI data engineer, telecom technicians, drone manufacturing and assembly technician and additive manufacturing or 3D printing. A national initiative, SOAR (Skilling for AI Readiness), has been launched to provide AI awareness and foundational skills among students of class VI onwards and build AI literacy among educators.

In fact, at a PM Kaushal Vikas Kendra in Delhi's Tilak Nagar run by JITM Skills, there is a mix of students—while some are pursuing graduation through correspondence, some are mid-career professionals who have enrolled in courses on social media influencing and digital marketing.

A new National Policy on Skill Development and Entrepreneurship is in the offing for 2025-35. The aim is to have a more futuristic focus, greater industry participation, and incentives like Skill Mudra vouchers to enable self-selection of skilling courses. The Impact Bond 2.0, which would channel more funding into skilling, is also proposed.

But, at the end of the day, there's a lot more that's needed, from all stakeholders. Krishna says while India still has a long way to go in skilling, countries like Germany, Japan and Singapore, which are known for their vocational education and skilling, have done this over a 30-40-year period.

What is also called for is a change in people's mindset. While everyone dreams of becoming a graduate and getting an office job, very few think of training as a carpenter, electrician or beauty technician. Changing this mindset could go a long way towards realising India's skilling ambitions. **BT**

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